Dyslexia has almost nothing to do with intelligence, and rather more to do with how the brain handles the sounds inside words.

In plain words

Dyslexia is a difference in how the brain processes the sound structure of language, which makes decoding written words slow and effortful. Reading can be learned, and often is — but it stays costly in a way it isn't for other people. Spelling and getting words out on the page are usually harder still.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Reading a paragraph three times and retaining none of it, because all the effort went on decoding.
- Knowing a word perfectly well and being unable to spell it, every single time.
- Reading aloud being a genuine dread, not a mild preference.
- Having the whole idea clearly in your head and losing it on the way to the page.
- Being exhausted by tasks other people describe as light reading.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"They see letters backwards."	That's a myth. It's about processing sounds, not reversing shapes.
"They're not very bright."	Dyslexia is unrelated to intelligence. Plenty of dyslexic people are exceptional thinkers.
"More reading practice will fix it."	Unstructured practice mostly builds dread. Structured, phonics-based teaching helps.
"They're just careless."	Proofreading your own work is precisely the thing dyslexia makes hardest.
"They'll grow out of it."	It's lifelong. What changes is the strategies and the confidence.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Big-picture thinking, and spotting patterns others miss.

Strong spatial and visual reasoning.

Excellent verbal reasoning and storytelling.

Creative problem-solving, from years of finding workarounds.

Perseverance built by doing hard things daily since childhood.

What actually helps

- ☐ Offer audio versions of anything long
- ☐ Accept voice notes instead of written ones
- ☐ Use clear fonts and generous spacing
- ☐ Never ask someone to read aloud unprepared
- ☐ Don't correct spelling in casual writing
- ☐ Give extra time as standard, not as a favour

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

“Want me to send that as a voice note?”

“Take whatever time you need.”

“I'll summarise the key bits.”

LESS HELPFUL

“Just sound it out.”

“You spelled that wrong.”

“Can you read this out for us?”

The thinking was never the difficult part. Only the getting it in and out.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk